

African empires

Since around 100 CE, powerful kingdoms have risen and fallen in the land south of the huge Sahara Desert in Africa. These kingdoms struggled to gain land and control of trade routes. Trading made rulers rich, especially through selling gold, ivory, and slaves. In addition to rich monarchs, there were many ordinary farmers in the forests and grasslands below the Sahara.



Sankore Madrasa Mosque

Timbuktu

The city of Timbuktu in West Africa was famous for being rich. Gold was mined from local goldfields and traded for other goods. Timbuktu was also a center of learning. There were three mosques where people could study. Sankore Madrasa Mosque was built in the 14th century.

Islam

North African traders crossed the Sahara Desert on camels to trade with Mali. They brought their religion, Islam, with them. In the ninth century, the people of Mali became Muslims. The Great Mosque of Djenné is the largest mud-brick building in the world.



African powers

The great African empires and kingdoms were to the south of the Sahara Desert, which stretches across North Africa.



Merchants crossed the Sahara on camels, carrying dates and other goods to trade.

Merchant and camels

The Kanem-Bornu Empire had a big army, with riders and horses who both wore armor.

Horseman

Ethiopian Christians made churches by carving them out of rocky hillsides.

Church of Bet Abba Libanos

Benin was the capital city of a rich kingdom. Metalworkers here made beautiful brass or bronze sculptures of their rulers.

Benin bronze

Gold was dug out of the ground in Mali.

Gold

Djenné

Timbuktu

Niger River

Gao

Benin city

Nile River

SCALE

0 500 miles

0 500 kilometers